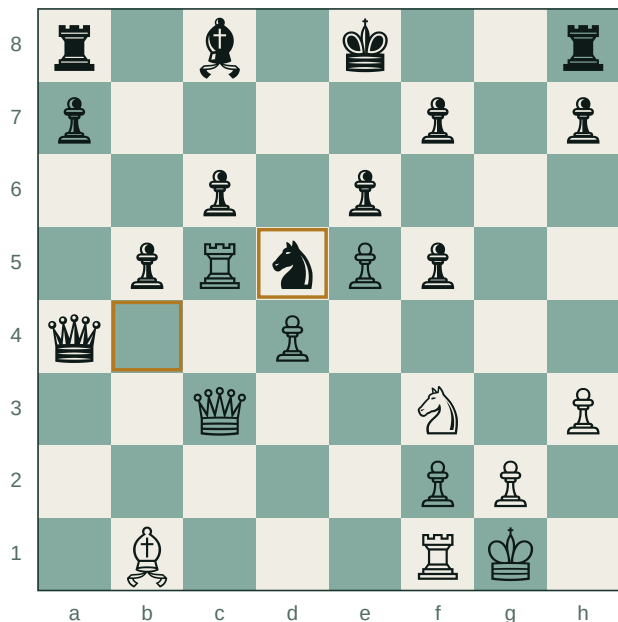


Clearance tactics: White, move 20

Clearance tactics

White to move



Previous move: 19...Nd5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20. Rxd5 cxd5 21. Qc6+

20.Rxd5 The rook captures the knight on d5. Recorded reply: **20...cxd5**.

21.Qc6+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From c6 it attacks king on e8, rook on a8 and bishop on c8.

At the end, nominal material is White 25 / Black 29 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by -2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -2: the balance goes from -2 to -4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.